*randomly*decides between the two colors at the moment the door is opened. But here's the strange part. The letter says that although your boxes work exactly the same way as mine—even though the spheres inside each one of our boxes *randomly* choose between flashing red or blue—our boxes somehow work in tandem. The letter claims that there is a mysterious connection, so that if there is a blue flash when I open my box 1, you will also find a blue flash when you open your box 1; if I see a red flash when I open box 2, you will also see a red flash in your box 2, and so on."

"Mulder, I'm really exhausted; let's let the parlor tricks wait till I get back."

"Scully, please. I know you're on vacation, but we can't just let this go. We'll only need a few minutes to see if it's true."

Reluctantly, Scully realizes that resistance is futile, so she goes along and opens her little boxes. And on comparing the colors that flash inside each box, Scully and Mulder do indeed find the agreement predicted in the letter. Sometimes the sphere in a box flashes red, sometimes blue, but on opening boxes with the same number, Scully and Mulder always see the same color flash. Mulder grows increasingly excited and agitated by the alien spheres but Scully is thoroughly unimpressed.

"Mulder," Scully sternly says into the phone, " *you* really need a vacation. This is silly. Obviously, the sphere inside each of our boxes has been programmed to flash red or it has been programmed to flash blue when the door to its box is opened. And whoever sent us this nonsense programmed our boxes identically so that you and I find the same color flash in boxes with the same number."

"But no, Scully, the letter says each alien sphere *randomly* chooses between flashing blue and red when the door is opened, *not* that the sphere has been preprogrammed to choose one color or the other."

"Mulder," Scully sighs, "my explanation makes perfect sense and it fits all the data. What more do you want? And look here, at the bottom of the letter. Here's the biggest laugh of all. The 'alien' small print informs us that not only will opening the door to a box cause the sphere inside to